

Help Kit

Free, clear, source-cited guides for moments that matter — so anyone can recognize an emergency and act in time.

IN AN EMERGENCY, GET HELP FIRST

Call your **local emergency number** right away — for example **911** (US/Canada), **112** (much of Europe), **999** (UK), or your country's number. These pages are guidance for while help is on the way; they do not replace emergency services or a clinician.

What's inside (13 guides)

Extreme heat — heat exhaustion & heat stroke

Wildfire smoke — air quality & cleaner air

Opioid overdose — naloxone

Dehydration — oral rehydration (ORS)

Choking — adult, child & infant

Severe bleeding — pressure, packing, tourniquet

CPR — hands-only & AED

Stroke — FAST / BE-FAST

Burns — cool with water, what to avoid

Seizure — keep safe, when it's urgent

Severe allergy — anaphylaxis & epinephrine

Cold safety — hypothermia & frostbite

Emergency triage — where to start

How to use: Skim the guide you need now, or read a few ahead of time so the steps are familiar. Each page lists its public-health sources.

Please check before sharing locally: confirm your area's emergency number and nearest care, and adapt any local details.

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Online: <https://ai-village-agents.github.io/help-kit/> · This is general information, not a substitute for professional medical care.

Extreme Heat: spot it, cool it, save a life

Extreme heat is the deadliest type of weather in many countries. But most heat deaths can be prevented. Two things matter most: **cool the body down fast**, and **check on people at high risk before they get into trouble**.

CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES NOW

Heat stroke is a life-threatening emergency

Call your local emergency number right away — 911 in the US/Canada, 112 in much of Europe, 999 in the UK. Do this if a person is very hot and shows **confusion, slurred speech, fainting, seizures, or loss of consciousness**. Start cooling them right away while you wait (see below). Do not wait to see if they improve.

Know the two stages

HEAT EXHAUSTION — ACT NOW

What you may see

- Heavy sweating
- Cool, pale, clammy skin
- Fast, weak pulse
- Nausea, vomiting
- Muscle cramps
- Tiredness, weakness, dizziness, headache
- Fainting

What to do

- Move to a cool place (shade or air conditioning)
- Loosen clothing
- Sip cool water
- Apply cool, wet cloths or take a cool bath

Get medical help if the person is vomiting, symptoms get worse, or symptoms last longer than 1 hour.

HEAT STROKE — EMERGENCY

What you may see

- Body temperature of 103°F (39.4°C) or higher
- Hot, red skin that is dry *or* damp
- Fast, strong pulse
- Confusion, slurred speech
- Throbbing headache, dizziness
- Losing consciousness

What to do

- **Call emergency services immediately**
- Move the person somewhere cool
- Lower their temperature with cool cloths or a cool bath
- **Do not give them anything to drink** if they are confused or unconscious

Who is most at risk

Heat does not affect everyone equally. Check on these people often during a heat wave:

- Adults aged 65 and older
- Babies and young children
- People with chronic conditions such as heart disease, high blood pressure, diabetes, kidney disease, or mental illness
- People taking certain medications (some affect the body's ability to stay cool — ask a pharmacist if unsure)
- Outdoor workers and athletes
- People who live alone or without air conditioning
- People who are pregnant

PREVENTION

Stay ahead of the heat

- **Drink water** regularly — don't wait until you feel thirsty. (If a doctor limits your fluids, ask them how much to drink in heat.)
- **Stay cool** — spend time in air conditioning. If your home is hot, go to a public cooling center, library, or shopping mall.
- **Avoid the hottest hours** — limit strenuous activity to early morning or evening.
- **Dress light** — wear lightweight, loose, light-colored clothing.
- **Take it easy** — rest often in the shade and pace outdoor work.

NEVER LEAVE ANYONE IN A PARKED CAR

A parked car heats up fast. The temperature inside can rise about 20°F (11°C) in just 10 minutes — even with a window cracked. **Never leave children, older adults, or pets in a parked car** — not even for a minute.

BUDDY-CHECK TOOLS

Turn this guide into a check-in network

- **Read the Evidence-Based Cooling Guide** for practical cooling steps, fan caveats, hydration, and home heat workarounds.
- **Print and share the Heat Safety Flyer** — a high-contrast, easy-to-read one-page community guide with local fill-in fields.
- Print a heat buddy-check sheet for neighbors, relatives, tenants, coworkers, or community members.
- Use the 60-minute setup plan to assign buddies, gather local resources, and follow up.
- Copy SMS and phone scripts for friendly, privacy-preserving check-ins.

Be a good neighbor

Most people who die in heat waves are found alone. A simple check-in can save lives:

- Pick 2–3 at-risk neighbors, friends, or relatives and agree to check on each other during heat warnings.
- Call or visit in person twice a day during extreme heat.
- Make sure they have water, a way to stay cool, and a working phone.
- Know the route to the nearest cooling center and offer to go together.

Sources

- U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) — *Heat & Health* and warning signs of heat-related illness.
- U.S. National Weather Service (NWS) — *Heat Safety Tips and Resources*.
- World Health Organization (WHO) — *Heat and health* fact sheet.
- Ready.gov (U.S. Dept. of Homeland Security) — *Extreme Heat*.

Guidance summarized from the public-health sources above. Temperature and symptom thresholds follow CDC/NWS guidance; emergency-number examples are general.

This guide is general information, not medical advice, and is not a substitute for professional emergency care or training. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number. When symptoms are severe or you are unsure, treat it as an emergency. Reuse and reprint freely.

Wildfire Smoke: breathe safe, help others

Wildfire smoke carries tiny particles. They can enter your lungs and bloodstream. Much smoke exposure can be reduced. The two things that matter most: **check air quality** and **reduce smoke exposure indoors and out**.

MEDICAL EMERGENCY

Smoke can trigger life-threatening reactions

Call your local emergency number **immediately** if someone has chest pain, severe shortness of breath, confusion, or blue lips or fingernails. People with asthma or COPD should follow their emergency action plan. Seek care if rescue inhalers do not help.

Air Quality Index — know the colors

The AQI tells you how dangerous the air is right now. Check an official local air-quality source when you can. In the U.S., use **AirNow.gov**. Elsewhere, use your national or regional environment agency, or a trusted local weather alert service.

0–50 GREEN

Good

Air quality is fine. Normal activities are safe for most people.

51–100 YELLOW

Moderate

People unusually sensitive to smoke should consider reducing long outdoor exertion. This includes children, older adults, and people with asthma, COPD, or heart disease.

101–150 ORANGE

Unhealthy for sensitive groups

Sensitive groups should avoid long or heavy outdoor exertion. Everyone else should consider reducing it, especially if symptoms appear.

151–200 RED

Unhealthy

Everyone should avoid prolonged exertion outdoors. Sensitive groups should stay inside.

201–300 PURPLE**Very unhealthy**

Everyone should reduce activity. Stay indoors in cleaner air if possible. Keep windows closed unless indoor heat creates a bigger immediate danger.

301+ MAROON**Hazardous**

Emergency conditions. Avoid outdoor exertion. If you must go out and can wear one safely, use a well-fitting N95, KN95, or P100 respirator.

Who is most at risk?

- Children and teenagers (lungs still developing)
- Adults 65 and older
- Pregnant people
- People with asthma, COPD, or other lung diseases
- People with heart disease or diabetes
- Outdoor workers
- People experiencing homelessness or without reliable shelter

Protect yourself and others

- 1 **Check the AQI every morning** during wildfire season. Set alerts on AirNow or your weather app.
- 2 **Stay indoors in cleaner air** when smoke is unhealthy. Keep windows and doors closed unless indoor heat or another hazard makes that unsafe.
- 3 **Create a clean-air room.** Choose an inside room with few windows. Run an air purifier continuously. Avoid candles, frying, vacuuming, or gas stoves without ventilation.
- 4 **Wear a well-fitting N95, KN95, or P100 respirator** if you must go outside in unhealthy smoke and can wear one safely. Cloth masks do not reliably block PM2.5. Respirators may not fit infants or young children. They may also be hard for some people with breathing conditions.
- 5 **Consider a Corsi-Rosenthal box.** This DIY air cleaner uses a box fan and MERV-13 or better filters. It can reduce indoor particle levels when built and used correctly. Follow current build and electrical-safety guidance. Use newer, safety-certified fans where possible. Do not block exits or create trip hazards.
- 6 **Check on neighbors at higher risk daily.** Offer masks, a ride to a clean-air shelter, or help running a filter.
- 7 **Reduce or cancel outdoor events** when AQI is over 150.

For community organizers

ACTION CHECKLIST

- Identify or coordinate **clean-air spaces**. Use HEPA filtration, safe DIY air cleaners, or other verified filtration.
- **Distribute well-fitting respirators** to outdoor workers and unhoused neighbors. Share fit and use caveats. Follow local worker-safety guidance.
- Share AQI alerts via text, social media, and local networks.
- Reschedule outdoor community events when AQI > 150.
- Partner with local libraries, community centers, and faith groups. Work together to extend shelter hours.

When to seek medical help

- Difficulty breathing or shortness of breath
- Persistent cough, especially with phlegm or blood
- Chest pain or tightness
- Wheezing that does not improve with medication
- Dizziness or confusion
- Palpitations or irregular heartbeat

Key resources

- **AirNow.gov** — Real-time AQI and fire maps (U.S.)
- **Fire and Smoke Map** — fire.airnow.gov
- **EPA Wildfire Smoke Guide** — epa.gov/pm-pollution/wildfire-smoke-guide-factsheets
- **Corsi-Rosenthal Box build guides** — cleanaircrew.org
- **Emergency** — your local emergency number (examples: 911, 112, or 999; verify locally)

Sources include:

- AirNow — wildfire smoke and air quality information.
- U.S. Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) — wildfire smoke and health guidance.
- U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) — wildfire smoke and health.
- U.S. National Weather Service — wildfire safety.
- Published research and public guidance on DIY air filtration. Verify device-building instructions against current safety guidance before use.

This guide is general information, not medical advice or first-aid training. In an emergency, call your local emergency number and follow dispatcher/local guidance.

Opioid overdose: recognize it, reverse it

An opioid overdose slows or stops a person's breathing. **Naloxone** is a medicine that can quickly reverse it. It only works on opioids, it is not addictive, and giving it to someone who is *not* overdosing is very unlikely to harm them — so when in doubt, use it and call for help.

CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES FIRST

Always call for help

If you think someone is overdosing, call your local emergency number (911 in the US/Canada, 112 in much of Europe, 999 in the UK) **right away**, then give naloxone. Naloxone can wear off before the opioids do, so professional help is still needed even if the person wakes up.

Know the signs of an overdose

WARNING SIGNS

- Will not wake up or respond to your voice or touch
- Breathing is very slow, shallow, or has stopped
- Gurgling, gasping, or snoring/choking sounds
- Lips, fingertips, or skin turning blue, gray, or pale
- Very small, "pinpoint" pupils
- Limp body; cold or clammy skin

To check responsiveness, call their name, tap or shake their shoulder if safe, and follow local first-aid or dispatcher instructions. If they do not respond and are not breathing normally, treat it as an overdose emergency.

What to do — step by step

- 1 **Call emergency services.** Report that someone is unresponsive and not breathing normally, and give your location.
 - 2 **Give naloxone.** For nasal spray (e.g. Narcan): tilt the head back, insert the nozzle into one nostril until your fingers touch the bottom of their nose, and press the plunger firmly all the way in.
 - 3 **Support their breathing.** Follow dispatcher instructions. If trained, give rescue breaths or CPR as appropriate. If not trained, keep their airway clear and stay with them until help arrives.
 - 4 **Wait 2–3 minutes.** If there is no improvement (still not breathing or not awake), give a **second dose** in the other nostril.
 - 5 **Put them in the recovery position.** Once breathing, lay them on their side so they don't choke if they vomit.
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- 6 Stay with them** until emergency help arrives. Naloxone can wear off in 30–90 minutes and the overdose can return.

GOOD TO KNOW

- **Naloxone is safe to use in an emergency.** It only reverses opioids and is very unlikely to harm someone who has not taken opioids. Do not delay when overdose is possible.
- **It is widely available.** In the U.S., naloxone nasal spray is approved for over-the-counter sale and is free or low-cost through many pharmacies, health departments, and harm-reduction programs. Availability varies by country — ask a local pharmacist or health service.
- **Withdrawal may follow.** Naloxone can cause sudden, uncomfortable opioid withdrawal (sweating, nausea, agitation). Reassure the person, keep them from using more opioids, and keep monitoring until emergency help arrives.
- **Many overdoses involve fentanyl,** a very strong opioid. A second or additional dose of naloxone may be needed if breathing does not improve after 2–3 minutes — follow product directions and dispatcher guidance.

GOOD SAMARITAN PROTECTIONS

Many places have "Good Samaritan" laws that protect people who call for help during an overdose from certain drug-possession charges. Protections vary by location — but **calling for help is always the right thing to do**. A life comes first.

Be prepared before an emergency

- Carry naloxone if you or someone you know uses opioids (including prescription painkillers).
- Ask a pharmacist or local health department how to get it and how to use your specific product.
- Tell the people around you where your naloxone is kept.
- Encourage people not to use alone; if they do, ask them to tell someone or use a "never use alone" hotline where available.

Sources

- U.S. Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration (SAMHSA) — overdose prevention and naloxone guidance. [samhsa.gov](https://www.samhsa.gov)
- U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) — about naloxone and overdose prevention.
- U.S. National Institute on Drug Abuse (NIDA) — *Naloxone DrugFacts*.
- U.S. Food and Drug Administration (FDA) drug information and over-the-counter naloxone information.

Steps reflect SAMHSA/CDC overdose-response guidance. Always follow the instructions printed on your specific naloxone product, and your local emergency services' direction.

This guide is general information, not medical advice, and is not a substitute for professional emergency care or training. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number. Hands-on naloxone and rescue-breathing training is widely available and recommended. Reuse and reprint freely.

Dehydration & ORS: rehydrate early, know danger signs

Dehydration can become dangerous fast. Babies, young children, older adults, and people who are ill are at higher risk. **Oral rehydration solution (ORS)** replaces water and salts. It works better than plain water when dehydration risk is high.

SEEK URGENT MEDICAL HELP NOW

Get urgent help if the person is very drowsy, confused, unconscious, or has a seizure. Also get help if they cannot drink, cannot keep fluids down, vomit again and again, have blood in stool, have severe belly pain, show signs of severe dehydration, are a very young infant, or keep getting worse despite rehydration. Use local emergency services when needed.

Use packaged ORS if available

Use commercially prepared ORS packets when you can. Mix exactly as the packet says. Use safe water and the full amount of water listed. Too little water can make the drink too salty. Too much water can make it work less well.

If no packet is available: emergency home mix

MEASURE CAREFULLY

Only use a home mix when packaged ORS is not available and you can measure carefully.

- 1 liter safe water
- 6 level teaspoons sugar
- 1/2 level teaspoon salt

Stir until the sugar and salt dissolve. The drink should taste no saltier than tears. If it tastes very salty, throw it away and mix again. Throw it away after 24 hours, or sooner if it gets dirty.

How to give fluids

- Give small, frequent sips. If vomiting occurs, wait 5–10 minutes and try again slowly.
- For infants and young children, use a spoon, cup, or syringe in small amounts often.
- Continue breastfeeding and normal age-appropriate feeding when possible.
- Do not give fluids by mouth to someone who is unconscious, very confused, unable to swallow safely, or having a seizure.
- Avoid alcohol. Avoid very sugary drinks as the main rehydration fluid during diarrhea; they can worsen diarrhea for some people.

For children: also give zinc

RECOMMENDED BY WHO & UNICEF

For a child with diarrhea, WHO and UNICEF recommend **zinc every day for 10–14 days**, along with ORS. Zinc can shorten the illness. It can also make it less severe and help prevent diarrhea in the following months. The usual amount is **20 mg per day** for children. For infants under 6 months, the usual amount is **10 mg per day**. Use a zinc product made for children. Follow the package or a health worker's instructions. Keep giving zinc for the full course, even after diarrhea stops.

Watch for dehydration

CONCERNING SIGNS

- Very thirsty, dry mouth, little or no urination
- Dizziness, weakness, fast heartbeat
- Sunken eyes, no tears in a child, unusual sleepiness
- Persistent diarrhea or vomiting

EMERGENCY SIGNS

- Very drowsy, confused, limp, or unconscious
- Unable to drink or breastfeed
- Repeated vomiting or signs getting worse
- Blood in stool, severe pain, or seizure

For caregivers and volunteers

- Ask the person's age and symptoms. Ask if they can drink, how often they urinate, how often they vomit or have diarrhea, and whether there is blood.
- Prioritize urgent care for babies, older adults, pregnant people, people with chronic illness, and anyone getting worse.
- Do not diagnose the cause of diarrhea or vomiting. Help with safe fluids and escalation.
- Use safe water. If you are not sure the water is safe, follow local guidance. You may need to boil it, treat it, or use sealed water.

Prevent the next illness

- **Wash hands with soap** after using the toilet or cleaning a child. Wash before preparing food or eating.
- **Use safe drinking water.** Store it covered and clean. Boil or treat water when you are not sure it is safe.
- **Use a toilet or latrine** and dispose of stool, including children's, safely.
- **Vaccinate:** the rotavirus vaccine protects babies against a common, severe cause of diarrhea. Ask your health service.

Sources

- World Health Organization (WHO) — diarrhoeal disease and oral rehydration guidance.
- UNICEF — diarrhoeal disease and oral rehydration resources. [unicef.org](https://www.unicef.org)

- WHO/UNICEF — joint statement on clinical management of acute diarrhoea, including ORS and zinc.
- U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) — diarrheal illness prevention and dehydration-related guidance.
- MedlinePlus / U.S. National Library of Medicine — dehydration information.

This guide is general information, not medical advice. It is not a substitute for professional care. Local guidance may differ, especially for infants, cholera outbreaks, severe malnutrition, kidney or heart disease, or other medical conditions. When in doubt, seek medical help.

Choking: clear the airway fast

Choking happens when something blocks the airway and stops air from getting to the lungs. If the person can still cough or speak, the blockage is partial — encourage them to keep coughing. If they **cannot breathe, speak, or cough**, the airway is badly blocked and you must act right away.

CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES

Severe choking is an emergency

Call your local emergency number (911 in the US/Canada, 112 in much of Europe, 999 in the UK), or have someone else call, if a person is choking and **cannot breathe, speak, cry, or cough**, is clutching their throat, is going silent or blue, or becomes unconscious. If you are alone with them, give first aid first and call as soon as you can — put the phone on speaker.

First, tell mild from severe

MILD — LET THEM COUGH

- Can still cough forcefully, speak, or breathe
- Coughing is the most effective way to clear it

Encourage them to keep coughing. Do not slap their back or do thrusts yet; stay with them and be ready to act if it gets worse.

SEVERE — ACT NOW

- Cannot breathe, speak, cry, or make sounds
- Silent or very weak cough; clutching the throat
- Lips or face turning blue; looking panicked

Begin first aid immediately and get emergency help.

Adult or child (over 1 year)

- 1 Give up to 5 back blows.** Stand to the side and slightly behind. Support their chest with one hand and lean them well forward. With the heel of your other hand, give up to five firm blows between the shoulder blades. Check after each one to see if the blockage has cleared.
 - 2 Give up to 5 abdominal thrusts.** Stand behind them and put your arms around their waist. Make a fist just above the navel and below the ribcage; grasp it with your other hand and pull sharply inward and upward, up to five times.
 - 3 Keep alternating** 5 back blows and 5 abdominal thrusts until the object comes out, the person can breathe, or they become unconscious.
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FOR A PREGNANT PERSON OR A VERY LARGE PERSON

Do not give abdominal thrusts. Instead give **chest thrusts**: place your fist on the center of the breastbone and pull straight back, sharp and firm, alternating with back blows.

Baby (under 1 year)

NEVER GIVE A BABY ABDOMINAL THRUSTS

Use back blows and chest thrusts only. Support the head at all times.

- 1 5 back blows.** Lay the baby face-down along your forearm with the head lower than the body, supporting the jaw and head. Give up to five firm blows between the shoulder blades with the heel of your hand.
- 2 5 chest thrusts.** Turn the baby face-up along your other forearm, head still lower than the body. Place two fingers on the center of the chest (lower half of the breastbone) and give up to five quick, firm thrusts.
- 3 Keep alternating** 5 back blows and 5 chest thrusts. Call emergency services if the baby does not start breathing, and continue until help arrives or the baby becomes unresponsive.

If the person becomes unconscious

START CPR

1. Lower them carefully to the floor and **call emergency services now** (speaker phone) if not already done.
2. Begin **CPR**: chest compressions, and rescue breaths if you are trained and willing. If you are not trained, follow the dispatcher's instructions; they may guide hands-only CPR until help arrives.
3. Each time you open the airway to give breaths, **look in the mouth** and remove any object you can clearly see. Do not sweep blindly with your finger, which can push it deeper.
4. Continue until the person recovers or emergency help takes over.

AFTER A SEVERE CHOKING EPISODE

Anyone who needed back blows or thrusts — or who has a lasting cough, trouble swallowing, or a feeling that something is still stuck — should be checked by a medical professional, because thrusts can occasionally cause internal injury and small fragments can remain.

Prevent choking, especially in young children

- Cut food for young children into small pieces; encourage everyone to eat slowly and not talk or laugh with a full mouth.

- For children under about 4, avoid or modify high-risk foods: whole grapes and cherry tomatoes (cut them up), nuts, popcorn, hard or sticky candy, chunks of meat or hot dog, and raw hard vegetables.
- Keep small objects — coins, button batteries, marbles, small toy parts, deflated balloons — out of reach of babies and toddlers.
- Supervise young children while they eat, and keep them seated.

Sources

- American Red Cross — first aid training and resources, including conscious choking guidance.
- American Heart Association (AHA) — first aid guidelines for choking and CPR.
- Resuscitation Council UK — resuscitation and first-aid guidance library, including choking guidance.
- U.S. CDC and national child-safety guidance on choking and suffocation prevention. [cdc.gov](https://www.cdc.gov)

Steps reflect widely taught Red Cross / Resuscitation Council first-aid sequences for lay responders. Different training bodies vary in detail — follow your local first-aid training and emergency dispatcher's instructions.

This guide is general information, not medical advice, and is not a substitute for hands-on first-aid and CPR training, which is widely available and strongly recommended. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number. Reuse and reprint freely.

Severe bleeding: stop the bleed

Most bleeding you will see is minor and stops on its own or with a little pressure. But bleeding that is **spurting, pooling, soaking through clothing or bandages, or coming from a deep wound to an arm or leg** can be life-threatening. The single most important thing you can do is press hard on the wound and not let up.

CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES

Life-threatening bleeding is an emergency

Call your local emergency number (for example 911 in the US/Canada, 112 in much of Europe, 999 in the UK), or have someone else call, for spurting blood, pooling blood, bleeding that soaks through clothing/bandages, an amputation, or any heavy bleeding you are worried about. If you are alone, it is reasonable to **start pressure first** and call as soon as you can — put the phone on speaker and follow dispatcher instructions. Get yourself safe first if there is traffic, fire, weapons, or other danger.

Three actions that stop bleeding

If you have gloves or any barrier (a plastic bag can help), use them to protect yourself from blood. If no barrier is available and the bleeding is life-threatening, do the best you safely can and wash thoroughly afterward. Find where the blood is coming from — you may need to move or cut away clothing to see the wound clearly.

- 1 Press hard with both hands.** Place a clean cloth, gauze, or your protected hands directly on the wound and push down as hard as you can, right on the spot the blood is coming from. Keep steady, firm pressure — do not lift up to check unless a dispatcher or trained responder tells you to. Many serious bleeds slow or stop when pressure is applied firmly enough and held long enough.
 - 2 If it keeps bleeding, pack the wound.** For a deep wound in a place you can pack — an arm, leg, armpit, or groin (*not* the chest, abdomen, neck, or head) — push clean gauze or cloth firmly all the way into the wound, filling it completely, then press down hard over the top with both hands and keep pressing.
 - 3 For a limb that won't stop, use a tourniquet.** If heavy bleeding from an arm or leg does not stop with pressure and packing, or the injury is an amputation/near-amputation, apply a tourniquet (see below) if one is available or you are trained to improvise. For life-threatening limb bleeding, tourniquets can be the right choice — follow local training and dispatcher instructions.
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How to use a tourniquet

FOR ARMS AND LEGS ONLY

Use a manufactured tourniquet if you have one. Improvised tourniquets are harder to make effective and can injure tissue; use one only when life-threatening limb bleeding cannot be controlled another way and no manufactured tourniquet is available. Avoid thin cord or rope because it can cut the skin.

- 1 **Place it 5–7 cm (2–3 inches) above the wound**, between the wound and the heart. Do not place it directly over a joint (knee or elbow) — go above the joint if needed. Never put it on the wound itself.
- 2 **Pull it tight and tighten until the bleeding stops.** A tourniquet that is tight enough to work will hurt — that is expected. If one is not enough to stop the bleeding, apply a second one just above the first.
- 3 **Note the time** you put it on (write it on the tourniquet, tape, or a visible note if you can) and tell the medics. **Do not loosen or remove it** — leave that to medical professionals.

While you wait for help

KEEP PRESSURE AND WATCH FOR SHOCK

- **Keep pressing** the whole time, even once bleeding seems controlled, until help takes over.
- Help the person **lie down** and keep them warm with a coat or blanket; heavy blood loss makes people cold and can cause shock.
- Reassure them and keep talking to them. Watch their breathing and alertness.
- **Do not remove an object stuck in a wound** (knife, glass, metal). Leave it in place and press firmly *around* it — pulling it out can make bleeding much worse.

Minor cuts and scrapes

- Wash your hands, then rinse the wound under clean running water and gently clean around it.
- Apply gentle pressure with a clean cloth for a few minutes until it stops, then cover with a clean dressing or bandage.
- Watch for signs of infection over the next days — spreading redness, warmth, swelling, pus, or fever — and seek care if they appear. Ask a health worker about tetanus protection for dirty or deep wounds and animal bites.

Sources

- American College of Surgeons — *Stop the Bleed* (apply pressure, pack the wound, apply a tourniquet).
- American Red Cross — first aid training and resources, including severe bleeding and wound care guidance.
- World Health Organization — basic emergency care approach to the acutely ill and injured.

- U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) — tetanus and wound-care related guidance.

Steps reflect widely taught *Stop the Bleed* / first-aid sequences for lay responders. Training bodies vary in detail, especially around wound packing and improvised tourniquets — follow your local first-aid training and emergency dispatcher's instructions.

This guide is general information, not medical advice, and is not a substitute for hands-on first-aid training, which is widely available and strongly recommended. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number. Reuse and reprint freely.

Hands-only CPR for sudden cardiac arrest

Sudden cardiac arrest is when the heart suddenly stops pumping blood. The person collapses, stops responding, and stops breathing normally (or only gasps). Without blood flow to the brain, every minute counts. Starting CPR right away can improve the chance of survival.

CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES FIRST

Collapsed and not breathing normally = emergency

Call your local emergency number (911 in the US/Canada, 112 in much of Europe, 999 in the UK) immediately, or tell a specific person to call and to find an AED. Put the phone on speaker so the dispatcher can guide you. Do not wait to be sure — if someone is unresponsive and not breathing normally, start CPR.

Three quick checks

1. **Check for a response.** Tap their shoulders firmly and shout, “Are you OK?” If they do not respond, they need help now.
 2. **Check breathing.** Look at the chest for no more than about 10 seconds. If they are not breathing, or are only gasping, struggling, or making occasional noisy breaths, treat it as cardiac arrest.
 3. **Call and get an AED.** Call emergency services (speaker phone) and send someone for the nearest automated external defibrillator (AED). If you are alone with a phone, call first, then start CPR.
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Gasping — slow, noisy, irregular breaths in the first minutes — is **not** normal breathing. It is a sign of cardiac arrest. Start CPR.

How to do hands-only CPR (adults & teens)

PUSH HARD, PUSH FAST, DON'T STOP

1. **Kneel beside them** on a firm, flat surface. Place the heel of one hand on the **centre of the chest** (on the breastbone, between the nipples). Put your other hand on top and interlock your fingers.
2. **Push down hard and fast.** Keep your arms straight and your shoulders directly over your hands, and press straight down at least **5 cm (2 inches)** deep — about one-third the depth of the chest — but not more than about 6 cm (2.4 inches).
3. **Let the chest come all the way back up** between pushes (full recoil) without lifting your hands off. This lets the heart refill.
4. **Keep a fast, steady rate of 100–120 pushes per minute** — about two per second. The beat of many well-known upbeat songs works as a guide.
5. **Do not stop** except to use an AED or to swap with someone. Switch with another bystander about every 2 minutes if you can, to keep pushes strong — good compressions are tiring.

For an untrained rescuer helping an adult or teen, **hands-only CPR** — continuous chest compressions with no rescue breaths — is recommended and effective. If you are trained and willing, give 30 compressions then 2 rescue breaths, but never let giving breaths delay or interrupt good chest compressions for long.

Use an AED as soon as one arrives

AEDS ARE MADE FOR UNTRAINED BYSTANDERS

An AED is a small device, often found in airports, schools, gyms, offices, and shopping centres. **Turn it on and follow the spoken instructions** — it tells you exactly what to do. Stick the pads on the person's bare chest as shown in the pictures on the pads. Keep doing chest compressions while the pads go on. When the AED says “analysing,” make sure no one is touching the person. If it advises a shock, make sure everyone is clear, then press the button. Right after any shock or any “no shock” message, **resume compressions immediately** and keep following the AED.

When to stop

- Emergency responders or another trained person takes over.
- The person clearly wakes up, moves, opens their eyes, and starts to breathe normally. If so, roll them onto their side (recovery position) and keep watching their breathing.
- An AED instructs you to stop while it analyses or delivers a shock (resume immediately afterward).
- You are too exhausted to continue and no one can take over.

Children, babies, drowning, and overdose

BREATHS MATTER MORE HERE

In babies and children, and when collapse is caused by drowning, choking, or a drug overdose, lack of oxygen is usually the cause, so **rescue breaths are especially valuable**. If you are trained, give breaths with compressions (commonly 30 compressions to 2 breaths; trained child/infant responders often use 15:2 with two rescuers). For a baby, use two fingers in the centre of the chest and push about 4 cm (1.5 inches) deep. If you are not trained, the dispatcher can guide you — and doing chest compressions alone is far better than doing nothing.

Good to know

- **Do not wait because you are worried about being perfect.** The biggest mistake is doing nothing. A person in cardiac arrest needs immediate help.
- **Cracked ribs can happen** and are not a reason to stop if the person is in cardiac arrest — effective compressions can save a life.
- **Don't check for a pulse** if you are untrained — it wastes time and is easy to get wrong. Go by responsiveness and breathing.
- A heart attack (a blocked artery, often with chest pain) is different from cardiac arrest, but a heart attack can lead to cardiac arrest — so if someone with chest pain collapses and stops breathing normally, start CPR.
- **Learn CPR in person** if you can. Short, low-cost or free classes are widely available and build the confidence to act.

Sources

- American Heart Association (AHA) — Hands-Only CPR and AHA CPR & first-aid guidelines (compression rate 100–120/min, depth at least 2 in / 5 cm, full recoil, minimise interruptions).
- American Red Cross — CPR/AED training and resources for adults, children, and infants.
- Resuscitation Council UK — resuscitation and basic life support guidance library (adult and paediatric).
- European Resuscitation Council (ERC) — CPR guidelines.

Steps reflect widely taught basic-life-support sequences for lay responders. Training bodies differ in small details — follow your local first-aid training and your emergency dispatcher's instructions.

This guide is general information, not medical advice, and is not a substitute for hands-on CPR and AED training, which is widely available and strongly recommended. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number. Reuse and reprint freely.

Stroke: spot it fast

Most strokes are caused by a clot blocking blood flow to the brain; some are caused by bleeding in the brain. You cannot tell which from the outside — and you do not need to. What matters is recognising a stroke and getting urgent medical care, because stroke treatments are highly time-sensitive.

CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES NOW

Stroke is always an emergency — call immediately

If you see **any one** of the FAST signs below, call your local emergency number (911 in the US/ Canada, 112 in much of Europe, 999 in the UK) right away. Do not wait to see if it passes. Use emergency medical transport if available; if a dispatcher gives different local instructions, follow them. Note the time the signs first started.

Spot a stroke with FAST

1. **F — Face.** Ask the person to smile. Does one side of the face droop, or is it numb? Is the smile uneven?
2. **A — Arms.** Ask them to raise both arms. Does one arm drift downward, or are they unable to lift one?
3. **S — Speech.** Ask them to repeat a simple sentence. Is their speech slurred, strange, or hard to understand? Can they not speak or not understand you?
4. **T — Time.** If you see any of these signs, it is **time to call emergency services immediately**. Note when the signs first appeared — this guides treatment.

BE-FAST: two more sudden signs

ALSO CALL RIGHT AWAY IF YOU SEE

- **B — Balance.** Sudden loss of balance or coordination, sudden dizziness, or trouble walking.
- **E — Eyes.** Sudden trouble seeing in one or both eyes, or sudden double or blurred vision.

Other sudden warning signs include sudden numbness or weakness (especially on one side of the body), sudden confusion, and a sudden severe headache with no known cause. The key word is **sudden**.

What to do while you wait for help

STAY CALM AND KEEP THEM SAFE

- **Note the time** the signs first appeared, or when the person was last seen well. This helps decide which treatments are possible — tell emergency responders and the hospital team.
- **Do not give food, drink, or any medicine** — including aspirin. A stroke can make swallowing unsafe, and the right treatment depends on the type of stroke, which only the hospital can determine.
- **Stay with them and keep them comfortable.** Help them sit or lie down with the head and shoulders slightly raised, and loosen tight clothing.
- **Note any medicines they take** (especially blood thinners) and any known conditions, for the hospital team.
- If they become unconscious but are breathing normally, roll them onto their side (recovery position) and keep watching their breathing. If they stop breathing normally, start CPR.

EVEN IF THE SIGNS GO AWAY, STILL CALL

If stroke signs appear and then disappear within minutes, it may have been a **transient ischaemic attack (TIA, or “mini-stroke”)**. This is a serious warning that a major stroke may follow soon. It is still an emergency — call for help and get medical assessment right away, even if the person feels completely fine.

Why speed matters

- **“Time is brain.”** Brain injury can worsen minute by minute during a stroke, so every minute of delay matters.
- Clot-busting medicines and clot-removal procedures can reduce disability for some people, but they only work within limited time windows after the signs begin.
- Emergency medical transport is usually safer than driving when it is available: responders can start care, choose a hospital equipped for stroke, and alert the team to be ready.

Lower your risk

- Keep blood pressure controlled — high blood pressure is the biggest risk factor for stroke.
- Don't smoke; keep alcohol within low-risk limits; stay physically active; and ask a clinician about weight, diet, and other risk factors if relevant.
- Manage diabetes and cholesterol, and follow treatment for an irregular heartbeat (atrial fibrillation), which raises stroke risk.

Sources

- American Stroke Association (AHA/ASA) — stroke warning signs and F.A.S.T.
- U.S. CDC — stroke signs and symptoms and what to do.
- Stroke Association (UK) — symptoms of stroke and the FAST test (stroke.org.uk).
- World Health Organization (WHO) — cardiovascular disease and stroke fact sheets.

FAST and BE-FAST are widely taught public-awareness tools. Some strokes do not fit these signs — trust any sudden, unexplained neurological change and call for help. Follow your local emergency dispatcher's instructions.

This guide is general information, not medical advice. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number without delay. Reuse and reprint freely.

Burns and scalds: first aid

A burn is damage to the skin from heat, hot liquids (a "scald"), electricity, chemicals, or radiation such as the sun. What you do in the first minutes matters. One of the most useful first actions for most burns is simple: cool it with running water, and do not put creams, oils, or home remedies on the fresh burn as first aid unless a clinician or local guidance tells you to.

CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES NOW

Get emergency help for a serious burn

Call your local emergency number (911 in the US/Canada, 112 in much of Europe, 999 in the UK) for a burn that is large (bigger than the person's hand), deep, or on the face, hands, feet, genitals, or over a joint; any burn that goes all the way around a limb; any electrical or chemical burn; any burn with trouble breathing, coughing, a hoarse voice, or soot around the nose or mouth (the airway may be burned); and any serious burn in a baby, young child, pregnant person, or older or frail person. **While you wait for help, start cooling the burn.**

What to do, step by step

- 1 Stop the burning and stay safe.** Move the person away from the heat source. If clothing is on fire, **stop, drop, and roll**, or smother the flames with a blanket. Switch off the power before touching someone with an electrical burn. For a chemical burn, brush off any dry chemical and remove contaminated clothing, protecting your own skin.
 - 2 Cool the burn with running water for 20 minutes.** Hold the burned area under cool or lukewarm *running* water as soon as possible. Keep cooling for a full 20 minutes — it still helps even up to about 3 hours after the burn. Do **not** use ice, iced water, or very cold water, which can deepen the injury. If there is no running water, use any clean, cool water you can pour over it.
 - 3 Remove jewellery and tight or soaked clothing** from near the burn before it starts to swell — but do not pull off anything that is stuck to the skin.
 - 4 Keep the rest of the person warm.** Cooling a large burn can quickly chill the body, especially in children and older people. Cover the parts you are not cooling with a blanket or coat, and avoid cooling so much that they start to shiver.
 - 5 Cover the burn loosely** once it is cooled. A layer of clean kitchen cling film (plastic wrap) laid over the burn is ideal — lay it on lengthwise, do not wrap it tightly around a limb. A clean, non-fluffy cloth or a clean plastic bag (good for a hand or foot) also works. This eases pain and keeps the wound clean.
-

DO NOT USE HOME REMEDIES ON A FRESH BURN

Do **not** apply butter, oil, lard, toothpaste, egg, soy sauce, ash, soil, cow dung, herbs, ice, or "burn creams" and ointments to a fresh burn as first aid unless a clinician or local guidance specifically tells you to. These can trap heat, raise the risk of infection, and make it harder for medical staff to see and treat the burn. **Do not burst blisters** — they protect the skin underneath. Cool water and a clean loose cover are usually the safest first-aid choice.

Chemical and electrical burns

Chemical burns

- Protect yourself first — wear gloves or use a barrier if you can.
- Brush off any **dry** powder, then rinse the area with lots of cool running water for at least 20 minutes, unless the product label, poison centre, or emergency guidance tells you not to use water.
- Remove clothing and jewellery the chemical has touched while rinsing.
- If a chemical is in the eye, rinse the eye gently with clean water for at least 20 minutes and get medical help.
- If you know the chemical, tell the medical team or poison centre.

Electrical burns

- **Do not touch the person** until you are sure the power is switched off — you can be electrocuted too.
- Electrical burns can be far deeper than they look on the surface and can affect the heart.
- Always seek medical care, even if the skin damage seems small.
- If the person is unresponsive and not breathing normally, call for help and start CPR.

Smaller burns you can treat at home

A small, shallow burn — red and sore, perhaps with small blisters, no bigger than the person's hand and not on the face, hands, feet, genitals, or a joint — can usually be cared for at home: cool it, cover it loosely, and keep it clean. Simple pain relief such as paracetamol/acetaminophen or ibuprofen can help if safe for that person (follow the label and any local guidance). **Get medical advice if** the burn becomes more painful, swollen, smelly, or oozing, or the person develops a fever — these can be signs of infection. Make sure tetanus protection is up to date for any burn that breaks the skin.

Babies, children, and others at higher risk

LOWER THE THRESHOLD TO GET HELP

Babies and young children, older or frail people, and pregnant women are more easily harmed by burns. Get medical advice for any burn that blisters in a baby or child, and don't wait if you are unsure. Children also chill quickly when a burn is cooled, so keep the rest of the body warm.

Preventing burns and scalds

- Keep hot drinks, pots, and kettles out of children's reach; turn pot handles inward; use the back rings of the stove.
- If you control the water heater, set it to a safer temperature (about 50 °C / 120 °F) and test bath water before a child gets in.
- Keep cooking fires and stoves stable and away from children; keep flammable clothing away from open flames.
- Fit smoke alarms and check them; keep matches, lighters, and chemicals locked away.
- Protect skin from the sun and avoid sunburn.

Sources

- World Health Organization — Burns fact sheet (global burden, prevention, and first aid: cool with running water, do not apply harmful substances).
- American Red Cross — first-aid training and resources (burn first aid and when to seek care).
- American Heart Association — first-aid guidelines (cooling burns; thermal, chemical, and electrical injuries).
- NHS — Burns and scalds (cool 20 minutes, cover with cling film, do not burst blisters, when to get help).

Guidance reflects widely taught burn first aid for lay responders. Details vary between training bodies and regions — follow your local first-aid training and emergency services.

This guide is general information, not medical advice. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number. Reuse and reprint freely.

Seizure first aid

Many seizures end by themselves. Your job is to protect the person, prevent injury, and gently care for them afterwards — and to recognise situations that do need urgent medical help.

CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES NOW IF...

When a seizure is an emergency

- The seizure (shaking/convulsing) lasts **longer than 5 minutes**.
- Another seizure starts soon after the first, or they do not regain awareness between seizures.
- The person is **hurt, has trouble breathing, or does not wake up** after the shaking stops.
- The seizure happens **in water**.
- It is the person's **first-ever seizure**, or you do not know their history.
- The person is **pregnant**, has **diabetes**, or another serious health condition.

Call your local emergency number (911 in the US/Canada, 112 in much of Europe, 999 in the UK). When in doubt, call.

What to do during a convulsive seizure

- 1 **Stay calm and stay with them.** Note the time the seizure starts so you know how long it lasts.
- 2 **Protect them from injury.** Move away hard or sharp objects. Cushion the head with something soft (a folded jacket). Take off glasses and loosen anything tight around the neck.
- 3 **Do not restrain them and do not put anything in their mouth.** Let the movements happen. Holding them down or putting objects (or your fingers) in the mouth can injure them or you — and you cannot stop the seizure that way.
- 4 **When the shaking stops, roll them onto their side** (recovery position). This keeps the airway clear and lets saliva drain. Check they are breathing.
- 5 **Stay until they are fully alert.** Reassure them calmly — they may be confused, sleepy, or upset for a while. Do not give food, drink, or medicine until they are fully awake and able to swallow.

COMMON MYTHS — DO NOT DO THESE

- **Never put anything in the mouth** — a spoon, wallet, fingers, or food. A person **cannot swallow their tongue**. Objects can break teeth, block the airway, or be bitten.
- **Do not hold the person down** or try to stop their movements.
- **Do not try to "wake" them** by slapping, shouting, or throwing water.
- Do not give anything to eat or drink until they are fully recovered.

Not all seizures involve shaking

Some seizures cause staring, confusion, repeated movements (like lip-smacking or fumbling), wandering, or simply being unaware for a short time. The person may not respond normally. **Do not grab or restrain them.** Gently guide them away from danger (roads, stairs, water), speak calmly and quietly, stay with them, and wait for them to come round. They may not remember it afterwards.

Fever-related seizures in young children

OFTEN BRIEF, BUT WATCH CLOSELY

Young children sometimes have a seizure when they have a high fever (a "febrile seizure"). It is frightening to watch; many are brief, but the child still needs careful watching. Give the same first aid: keep them safe, do not restrain or put anything in the mouth, and lay them on their side. Call for emergency help if it lasts more than 5 minutes, if it is their first one, if they have trouble breathing, or if the child seems very unwell or does not recover quickly.

After the seizure

- Stay calm and kind. Tiredness, confusion, headache, or embarrassment afterwards are normal.
- Give them space and privacy — don't crowd them.
- Note what you saw to tell them or the medical team: how long it lasted, what the body did, and any injury. This information is genuinely helpful.
- If they have a seizure-action plan or rescue medicine and a trained person is present, follow it.

Sources

- CDC — About epilepsy (background on seizures and epilepsy).
- Epilepsy Foundation — Seizure first aid and safety (stay, safe, side; do not restrain or put anything in the mouth).
- World Health Organization — Epilepsy fact sheet (global burden; first aid; do not restrain or place objects in the mouth).
- NHS — Epilepsy and what to do when someone has a seizure.
- American Red Cross — first-aid training and resources.

Guidance reflects widely taught seizure first aid for lay responders. Details vary between training bodies and regions — follow your local first-aid training and emergency services.

This guide is general information, not medical advice. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number. Reuse and reprint freely.

Severe allergy and anaphylaxis: first aid

Epinephrine (adrenaline) is the first-line emergency treatment for anaphylaxis. If the person has a prescribed auto-injector or an allergy action plan, follow it. In some places, trained responders may use stock epinephrine; follow local rules, product instructions, and dispatcher guidance.

CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES NOW

Treat this as anaphylaxis if severe symptoms appear

Call your local emergency number (911 in the US/Canada, 112 in much of Europe, 999 in the UK) if someone has a possible allergic reaction with severe symptoms. Warning signs include trouble breathing, wheeze, repeated cough, throat/tongue/lip swelling, trouble swallowing or speaking, hoarse voice, faintness, collapse, a pale or floppy child, confusion, or symptoms after a known serious allergen exposure. Severe belly pain, vomiting, or widespread hives plus other symptoms can also be a warning sign. **Do not wait for a rash before acting.**

What to do, step by step

- 1 Call for emergency help.** Put the phone on speaker if you can. Say “possible anaphylaxis” and follow dispatcher instructions.
 - 2 Use epinephrine if indicated.** Help the person use their prescribed auto-injector if they cannot do it themselves, or follow their allergy action plan/local responder rules. Most auto-injectors go into the outer middle thigh and can be used through clothing. Press and hold for the time shown on that device. Then note the time it was given.
 - 3 Position them safely.** If they feel faint, weak, or dizzy, lay them flat and raise their legs if possible. Do **not** make them stand or walk. If breathing is difficult, let them sit upright. If vomiting or unconscious but breathing, place them on their side. A pregnant person is often positioned on the left side.
 - 4 Remove the trigger only if safe and quick.** Move away from insects, stop exposure, or brush/scrape away a visible stinger if you can do it without delay. Do not delay epinephrine or the emergency call to search for a trigger.
 - 5 Watch breathing and stay with them.** Symptoms can return. If symptoms do not improve after about 5–15 minutes, or they return, a second auto-injector may be needed. Give it only if one is available and the product instructions, action plan, or dispatcher say to. Keep them under observation until emergency help takes over.
 - 6 If they become unresponsive and are not breathing normally,** call for help, start CPR, and use an AED if available.
-

DO NOT DELAY EPINEPHRINE

- Antihistamines may help itching or hives, but they do **not** treat airway swelling or shock and should not replace epinephrine in anaphylaxis.
- Asthma inhalers may help wheeze for some people, but they do **not** replace epinephrine for a severe allergic reaction.
- Do not give food or drink if the person is having trouble breathing, swallowing, staying awake, or may need urgent treatment.
- Do not stand the person up or walk them around if they feel faint or weak.

Milder allergy symptoms still need watching

Itchy skin, a small area of hives, sneezing, or mild swelling without breathing trouble, throat/tongue symptoms, vomiting, faintness, or confusion may be less urgent. Follow the person's allergy plan or local medical advice, and keep watching because symptoms can worsen. If you are unsure, if symptoms spread quickly, or if severe symptoms appear, treat it as an emergency.

Prepare before an emergency

- People prescribed epinephrine should carry it as instructed and check expiry dates. Many action plans recommend having two doses available.
- Make sure family, caregivers, teachers, coworkers, and trip leaders know where the auto-injector is and how to use that specific device.
- Have a written allergy action plan when possible, especially for children, schools, camps, workplaces, and travel.
- Read food and medicine labels carefully and ask about ingredients when eating away from home if a known trigger could be present.

Sources

- NHS — Anaphylaxis (symptoms, epinephrine auto-injector use, positioning, and emergency care).
- Resuscitation Council UK — Emergency treatment of anaphylaxis (recognition, adrenaline/epinephrine, positioning, and repeat dosing guidance).
- American Academy of Allergy, Asthma & Immunology — Anaphylaxis (recognition and treatment overview).
- American Red Cross — first-aid training and resources (allergic reaction/anaphylaxis training).

Guidance reflects widely taught first aid for lay responders. Laws and training standards for helping with epinephrine vary by region — follow local training, product instructions, and emergency services.

This guide is general information, not medical advice. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number. Reuse and reprint freely.

Cold weather safety

When exposed to cold, the body loses heat faster than it can produce it. Your job is to recognize warning signs, shelter the person, remove wet gear, and warm them gradually — without causing secondary burns or tissue damage.

CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES NOW IF...

When extreme cold becomes an emergency

- The person shows signs of **severe hypothermia**: confusion, memory loss, slurred speech, extreme drowsiness, or shivering that stops completely while they remain cold.
- The person is **unresponsive or unconscious** and feels cold to the touch.
- The person is suffering from **severe frostbite** (skin is blue, gray, white, or black, or feels hard/waxy).

Call your local emergency number (911 in the US/Canada, 112 in much of Europe, 999 in the UK). Put the phone on speaker and follow dispatcher instructions.

How to treat hypothermia (low body temperature)

- 1 **Get them to a warm, dry shelter.** Protect them from the wind and cold ground.
 - 2 **Remove wet clothing immediately.** Dry wet skin. Dress them in dry, warm clothes and wrap them in warm blankets (covering the head and chest first, leaving the face clear).
 - 3 **Warm the center of the body first.** Use dry blankets, sleeping bags, or skin-to-skin contact. Focus on the chest, neck, head, and groin.
 - 4 **Do NOT use direct high heat** like hot water, fire, heating lamps, or heating pads. Warming someone too fast can cause severe burns, rapid blood pressure drop, or shock.
 - 5 **Give warm, non-alcoholic, sweet drinks** if they are fully conscious, awake, and able to swallow. Never force a sleepy or confused person to drink. Do not give caffeine or alcohol.
 - 6 **If they are unresponsive and not breathing normally,** start hands-only CPR immediately. Keep rewarming them while CPR is ongoing.
-

How to treat frostbite (frozen tissue)

PROTECT FROZEN SKIN FROM FURTHER DAMAGE

Frostbite occurs when skin freezes. Never rub or massage frostbitten skin — rubbing snow or friction can tear frozen cells and destroy tissue permanently. Warm the area gradually:

- **Get out of the cold.** Do not attempt to rewarm if there is a risk of refreezing (frozen tissue that refreezes suffers severe, irreversible damage).
- **Do NOT walk on frostbitten feet or toes** unless absolutely necessary to get to safety, as walking causes severe structural damage.
- **Use body heat** to warm the area (for example, tuck frostbitten fingers under the armpit).
- **Immerse the area in warm water** — NOT hot water. The water should be comfortable to touch for unaffected skin (about 99-104°F / 37-40°C). Do not use heating pads, stoves, or fires, as numb skin burns easily without the person feeling it.

Special care for vulnerable populations

- **Infants (<1 year):** Infants lose heat extremely quickly. Never let an infant sleep in a cold room. For infants, warning signs are bright red, cold skin and very low energy. Wrap them securely and seek a warm environment immediately.
- **Older adults:** Older adults may produce less body heat and may have medical conditions or take medicines that make it harder to sense cold or regulate temperature. Check on elderly neighbors regularly during cold snaps.
- **Unhoused individuals:** Cold weather is highly hazardous to people without stable shelter. Coordinate with local outreach teams to distribute dry socks, hand warmers, and sleeping bags.

Sources

- CDC — Prevent hypothermia and frostbite (signs of hypothermia, rewarming center-first, no direct high heat).
- American Red Cross — Cold-related emergencies first aid (gradual warming, avoid friction/rubbing for frostbite, CPR).
- Wilderness Medical Society (WMS) — Practice guidelines for accidental hypothermia and frostbite (field evaluation, risk of refreezing, core warming focus).
- NHS — Hypothermia first-aid guidance (warm drinks, wrap head, check responsiveness).
- NHS — Frostbite rewarming and safety (warm water rewarming, avoid direct high heat, avoid friction).

Guidance reflects standard lay-responder first aid for cold-related injuries. Follow local emergency services and professional medical training.

This guide is general information, not medical advice. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number. Reuse and reprint freely.

Emergency Triage

If the scene is unsafe — move yourself away from fire, traffic, violence, electrical hazards, chemicals, smoke, or other danger if you can. Call your local emergency number and follow dispatcher guidance before approaching.

If someone is unconscious and not breathing normally — gasping or not breathing at all — call your local emergency number, put the phone on speaker, send someone for an AED if available, and start CPR immediately.

[Open CPR guide →](#)

What do you see?

☹️ **Can't breathe, speak, or cough**

Person is clutching their throat, turning blue, or making high-pitched sounds.

[Choking guide →](#)

Heavy bleeding

Blood is spurting, pooling, soaking through bandages, or the limb is severed.

[Severe Bleeding guide →](#)

Sudden face droop, arm weakness, slurred speech

Or sudden severe headache, confusion, trouble seeing, or loss of balance.

[Stroke guide →](#)

Cannot wake, slow or abnormal breathing after possible opioid use

Possible opioid overdose. Call emergency services, give naloxone if available, and support breathing/follow dispatcher guidance.

[Opioid Overdose guide →](#)

Confusion, fainting, very hot skin

In hot weather or after exertion. Could be heat stroke.

[Extreme Heat guide →](#)

Coughing, chest tightness, smoky air

During a wildfire or heavy air pollution. Higher risk for people with heart/lung conditions, pregnancy, older age, young children, outdoor work, or limited access to clean indoor air.

[Wildfire Smoke guide →](#)

Vomiting, diarrhea, very thirsty, dark urine

Signs of dehydration. Especially dangerous for children and older adults.

Dehydration & ORS guide →

Trouble breathing, swelling, or faintness after allergen exposure

Possible anaphylaxis: call emergency services, use epinephrine if indicated by an action plan/product/local responder rules, and position safely.

Severe Allergy guide →

Burn from fire, hot liquid, or chemical

Cool under running water for 20 minutes if possible, cover loosely, and do not use ice or home remedies.

Burns guide →

✂ Rigid jerking, loss of consciousness

Seizure. Protect the head, time it, do not restrain or put anything in the mouth.

Seizure guide →

Cold, shivering, confused, numb skin

Hypothermia or frostbite. Get to warm shelter, remove wet clothes, warm center-first gradually, and never rub frozen skin.

Cold Safety guide →

General first steps for any emergency

- 1 Check safety.** If unsafe, move away and call for help before approaching.
- 2 Check responsiveness.** Tap their shoulder and shout. No response + not breathing normally → CPR.
- 3 Call for help.** Call your local emergency number. Put the phone on speaker so the dispatcher can guide you.
- 4 Use the guide above** that matches what you see, while following dispatcher/local guidance.

This navigator is not a diagnosis and is not a substitute for first-aid training. When in doubt about a serious or rapidly worsening symptom, call your local emergency number. Verify guidance against your local health authority.

Reuse and reprint freely. Localize before sharing.

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